May 2026

PNIMA Israel — Local Democracy Index

Strengthening Local Governance, Trust, and Social Cohesion in Israel

Executive Summary

Israel is facing a dual crisis of governance and social cohesion, reflected in declining public trust and increasing polarization. At a time when the relationship between citizens and institutions is under growing strain, the local arena presents a critical opportunity for rebuilding that trust. PNIMA's Local Democracy Index is a first-of-its-kind national tool designed to systematically measure, strengthen, and institutionalize democratic practices at the municipal level, where government is closest to citizens and where a shared society can begin to take root.

The Challenge

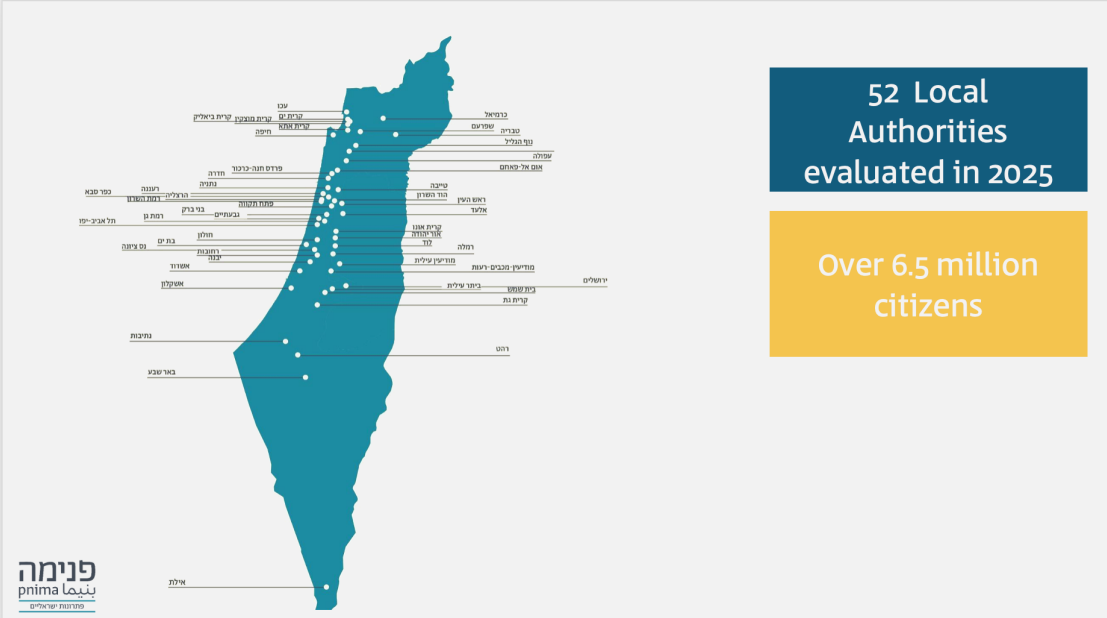
Israel remains one of the most centralized democracies in the OECD, which limits the ability of local authorities to respond effectively to the diverse and evolving needs of their communities. At the same time, efforts to decentralize authority carry significant risks if they are not accompanied by strong democratic infrastructure. Without mechanisms that ensure transparency, accountability, and meaningful public participation, decentralization can weaken public trust rather than strengthen it, and may concentrate power without sufficient checks and balances.

Our Solution

The Local Democracy Index offers a comprehensive and data-driven framework for assessing and improving democratic governance across municipalities. Rather than focusing solely on administrative or financial performance, the Index examines the quality of democratic life itself, capturing how decisions are made, how citizens are represented, and how trust is built between residents and their local governments. It does so by **evaluating six core dimensions: transparency, representation, public participation, trust, checks and balances, and civic engagement** and by integrating multiple data sources, including government data, municipal information, and representative citizen surveys. This combined approach enables the generation of actionable insights that are both comparable across municipalities and tailored to the specific needs of each locality.

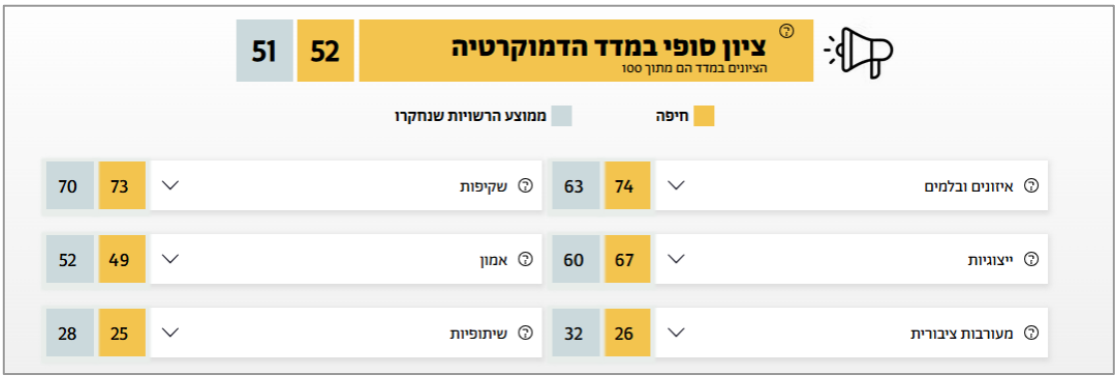
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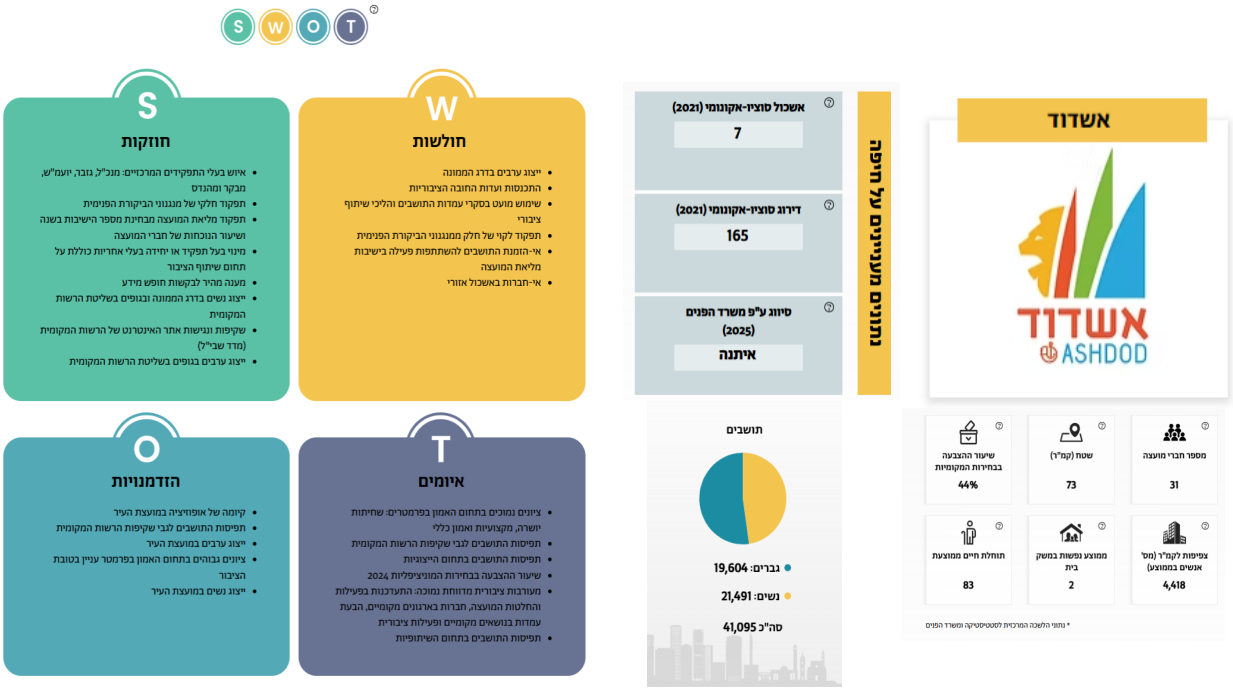
The Index has already moved from concept to implementation, with an initial **national pilot conducted across 15 major cities**. Since then, the measurement has expanded significantly and now reaches municipalities **representing over 65% of Israel's population.** The findings have been made publicly available, increasing transparency and accountability, and have been translated into tailored policy recommendations for each participating municipality. As a result, the Index is gaining recognition among policymakers and local leaders as a practical tool for strengthening governance and enabling responsible decentralization.



Strategic Vision

Looking ahead, PNIMA is working to scale the Local Democracy Index into a national standard that can serve as a consistent benchmark for evaluating democratic performance across municipalities. The goal is for the Index to inform government decision-making, guide decentralization reforms, and support the allocation of resources in a way that incentivizes strong democratic practices. Over time, this will contribute to strengthening democratic culture at the local level and rebuilding public trust at scale.





Funding Opportunity

Support for this initiative will first and foremost enable the integration of the Local Democracy Index into national policy frameworks, positioning it as a central tool for guiding decentralization, informing decision-making, and shaping resource allocation based on democratic performance.

In parallel, it will allow for deep, hands-on work with municipalities, supporting local leadership teams in translating insights into practice. This includes building tailored implementation processes, strengthening mechanisms of transparency, participation, and accountability, and embedding measurable improvements in democratic governance over time.

Finally, support will enable the expansion of the Index to additional municipalities and the continued development of the Index.

Why It Matters

Strong local democracy is not only a matter of governance, it is a foundation for national resilience. By strengthening municipalities as democratic institutions, we create the conditions for rebuilding trust, reducing polarization, and fostering a more cohesive and inclusive society across Israel.